

Testimony of a Loved One

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This place is ennobled with pith and despair; I have found myself consumed by it. I hadn't been here long when I came to realize this, perhaps it has been the season of rains that has eroded my better self. Or maybe it was the pallid, disdainful looks on passersby that caused my mind to think of strange, odd pieces of philosophy and reason. Whatever had happened, I had come to a point in my life that things were starting to change.

Nothing could quell the sinking of my nature, not even writing which had always helped me to cleanse my thoughts. I was in a different place at an indifferent time in the world, there was no place for thought or expression, just an acrid sense of slipping away amongst the tourists and permanent population. I could have put myself on high and held comfort in the notion that I was somehow above it all, but this in itself only contributed to my falling away.

In the decade before, I had been a fan of planning my life, it took me ten years to realize what I wanted to do with my career and even now as I am carrying out this task, it seems more trite as each day passes. How has the world at the dawn of the 21st Century used knowledge like the one I espouse? All bombs and wars on philosophies. There is no middle ground, only a balance between extremes.

I have always fancied myself as a writer; in the times between short stories and novellas, I have found myself miserable for having not done enough to contribute to the world. So, I shifted my focus to science, physics primarily, and for a time it filled the void with equations and interesting problems for my mind to solve. The solutions I devised didn't necessarily agree with the repose of the intellectual foundation and I quickly found myself a pariah in my own culture. I published several papers on my results but they have been largely ignored by the annuals. I do not bear any malice regarding my fate but find myself wondering my place and position here. I realize I know something profound, something that could alter

the very nature of space and time but I dare not construct the machine. I had built a prototype once and it did exactly as I had predicted but the consequences I dare not publish; it's enough to be ignored but quite another to be considered a hack—venturing from a point of no return back to reality is something quite impossible. So I have been careful with my methodology and pointed with my words. Nevertheless, I still cannot shake the ennui that is slowly engulfing me.

I arrived in Europe about two years ago. I began with a stay in Paris for half a year and eventually wandered to the east. Since that time, I have lived in Amsterdam, Minsk, Kiev, Vilnius, Budapest, and Moravia before finding myself in Prague. The premise for these journeys was that I was looking for a suitable graduate school to undertake my Doctorate in Physics. But I wasn't really looking for a school, I was looking for a new home. I feel as if I have been rejected by my people and my culture—perhaps this isn't exactly true. When I think about it, I think that I don't want to have my work being used in the systematic killing of wide swaths of peoples I would never get to know. My work should try to rise above the putrid wars and if not offer a solution or alternative, then force the change on the global society by proxy. I don't feel that it is my place to perform such a feat, but can feel it in the small spaces of time where it slowly drives me crazy.

The only pleasing times in my life are when I dream. It is in dreams that I get the sense of my position relative to my work and desire; it is also the place where my subconscious tries to make sense of the waking world. Sometimes dreams protrude in this way. Sometimes they show me what direction to take and less often what decisions to make. I have been thinking about one in particular.

I am standing in a circle of men. They are wearing snappy, pressed uniforms of tan ribboned with green; beyond them I can see the darkening room become smaller, the walls pulling in until they stop just beyond the circle. This action is followed by an eerie scraping noise carrying an enormous mass. The room shakes. As my eyes return to the men, I notice all but one are wearing hoods with blindfolds stitched in them. The hoods, green in color and striped in a solid white band, fit just on the crown of the skull and the blindfolds are made from small pieces of grey fabric fitting just over each eye. The unhooded man presents me with a small red velvet case,

“We want to present you this,” he begins slowly. “As a token of our appreciation.”

He places the case in my hand and I notice it is relatively heavy. Not really heavy but weighty as if something of compacted metal is resting within. I start to open the case and as I look to the man, he is pulling the hood over his eyes. The case lid creaks as I try to fold it open and inside a crudely made medallion peeks out at me, gleaming greyly in the dim light of the now small room. I squint to read the inscription on the rough surface but can only make out '*kde je dale?*' (where is the way?). The medallion seems to get heavier in my hand and soon I am trying to hold it with both hands. The men stand motionless in the small, squat room; a loose piece of fabric is blowing in an invisible wind on the wall just behind the one facing to my front. Soon the case is too heavy to hold and I drop it on the floor. The medallion jumps out and shatters on the floor. A wind tears through the room and the walls blow back away from the circle. The men stay fixed, each facing in to me, motionless as the wind turns from breeze to gale. They are fixed, unmoving, able to neither see nor affect the world only I am participating in. The case is broken, its lid unhinged, the medallion in shards, the pieces now orbiting the circle of men, dragging across the floor in a sickening thump. I hear voices on the wind.

"Kde je dale, kde je nassim..?"

For a moment a source of light appears in the stretched darkness. It is one star, then another, then a bright one far off, then two very bright ones very near. Around the two bodies a series of five planets orbit. One of them is blue and has water on its surface. The scene focuses tightly on the planet and it has taken the place of the blindfolded man just before me. I see it is rather small, two moons and a debris field surrounding it. The debris field is made of the shards from the broken medallion, some objects still carry the writing but it is twisted, convoluted, unutterable. I quit the shards and look closely at the planet, it has continents and stone cities and breathable air. If I squinted, I could see large movements of population across its surface. But I can't see it that well, it is pulling away from me and the wind is dying down, the room is becoming dark and the men are disappearing into the fabric of space where the planetary system resides. The walls are returning to their first position and I feel as if I'm about to wake...

The world is black and black, a vast uncharted landscape devoid of light or objects. I can feel its oiliness over my skin and the smell of putrid diesel in my nose. There is a feeble green light emanating from some unknown source; it is flashing as regular as a ticking clock. My emotions are calm,

as the still waters on the small planet. I am the source and the fruit of all labors. I am the architect staring at a blank piece of engineering paper, what I etch will stand for a thousand years. I am history and I am not exactly a piece of it; I flow between history and space and time. I am the ancient people who populate all the planets in the galaxy and I am no one. I am tangible and I am a wraith. The blackness is fading, the green light vanishing into some unseen horizon.

I am standing in a ruined flat in an unkempt part of town. Dust and debris, bits of concrete, plaster, and decay cling to the corners and lay out in large unbroken sheets across the floor. The room is empty save a small rickety table and a computer. I am at my laptop watching myself typing furiously at the keyboard. Torrents of letters, sentences, and paragraphs assault the screen. A swirl of smoke is rising from the top of my head, my hair is white and long and standing on end. I try to see what I am writing, to at least catch a glimpse of the title. My eyes strain to read the words, I believe they are in English but I cannot be certain.

Annals in Physics, The Glide-Stream of Space-Time and the Journey to its Far Reaches

What about the first sentence, can I read that? I must move closer to the screen. But I find that I cannot move closer, there is an invisible, almost magnetic force that is repulsing me from approaching. The force is coming from the other me at the computer.

“In times such as these, man must consider the what is beyond the limits of his science...what we know today is what was known two thousand years ago...we cannot escape our fate unless we look somewhere completely different...where is there new excitement that holds high promise...not here, not anywhere near here...but in the depths of space and time where our thoughts must inevitably coalesce with matter...the mind is the boundary dweller, the machine the bridge leaving this world commencing an era of discovery not dared dreamt before...this design I proffer exists beyond the limit of what is known to that which is unknown and unforeseen...beyond time is what awaits us...”

I am fairly close to myself now, I am pushing with all my might against the repulsive force. As if sensing my presence, I at the computer turn to look at myself. He smiles wryly and winks knowingly.

“If you only knew what I know, then you'd have something to worry about.”

But I am not me, he is somebody else. Me, yes, but a shade something

different. He doesn't even really look like me but I sense we are the same. Perhaps from a different time or a different set of circumstances, but nevertheless, we are identical. He stands staring at me.

"You know what the answer is, you have always known. Why must you not see it?"

"I have no idea what you are talking about," I croak feebly.

"Don't give me that. You have read my work and you have founded my work. Without you I could not have done what I've planned to do and what I'm going to do."

The computer moans, its fan beating rhythmic, incomprehensible phrases.

"You have brought life where there once was none," he continues while patting the computer which is now beginning a slow crescendo to a wail. "You have seen the future."

The computer is wailing loudly now and is slowly assembling a tune from the random utterances. It is regular and systematic, organized. He smiles at me, his eyes a dark brown, almost black like the fabric of space but without pinpoints of light. I can feel the vastness behind his gaze.

"Look to the mirror and find the answer, my friend. And we'll both be better for it."

I quickly thrust my eyes open to the wail of the alarm. I must have forgotten to turn it off from the week before when I had a teaching job.

While traveling through Europe, I have filled my waking hours by performing research projects I feel test the limits of my intelligence and imagination. If, according to the Greeks, everything has been done there must be some interesting work in the small spaces in between. After a few weeks in Prague, a paper was nagging in my brain. I ignored the impulse and instead filled my time by hanging out by the river and in subterranean pubs in Vinohrady. But my neglect was to manifest revenge in the form of piercing headaches and I found that I had to write the paper.

Thoughts and Reflections of a Man Caught Between Himself and the World he has Created

Between the past and the future lies what is undone. Despite the obviousness of the statement, it remains, in terms of physics, that this is all that there is—there is no more. Time is the only vehicle of change. It is an

inescapable conclusion that will be reached in any discussion. But what is time, this phenomenon we experience so linearly?

Einstein in the early 20th Century said that time was relative. In his paper on the Twin Paradox, he noted that the flow of time is dependent upon the point of view of the observer. In his argument, one twin sets out on a voyage into space at the speed of light. He travels a set distance, ten light-years out and ten light-years back. When the twin returns to Earth, he discovers that many centuries have passed and his twin has long perished. Minkowski, Einstein's professor, agreed with him and, as a consequence, was the first to devise the higher order of geometry necessary to understand the paradox. Greeted with great skepticism at the time, their contention relies on the premise that the observer is participating in the omnipresent flow of time upon a space-time manifold. Wigner, more specifically, speaks of a spatial-temporal manifold where time is a property of the system just as the spatial coordinates are. What if, for the sake of a tangible argument, the observer could remove himself temporarily from the manifold and freely extrapolate positions in space independent of time and in time independent of space? What if he could retain this theoretical removal from the manifold and manipulate its properties? How could such a thing be accomplished? In the paradigm of language this may be hard to devise. But conceptually it is not unreasonable to assume that a machine could aid such a feat. It has been written in antiquity that Buddhist monks could remove themselves from time and see the future and visit the past. Now this distinction is interesting. They *see* the future and *visit* the past. Assuming there are no errors in translation, this means that the past is fixed and the future is not since it is dependent upon the past.

A scientist of recent fame in the late 20th Century named Samuel Untermyer constructed a device called *The Cipher* which was reputed to remove a person from his temporal trappings allowing him to navigate time and space. He argued his machine was based on earlier archaeological evidence of other machines. The story goes something like this.

Around 1935, a team of archaeologists from Britain accidentally discovered a temple while exploring some ruins in Tunisia. The temple was relatively unremarkable and fit the time when it was constructed, about 2100BC. In one of the chambers deep inside the temple was a door embossed with a seal of the pharaoh, Markiddu, warning the contents of the room should not be disturbed on his order, under penalty of execution. Breaking the seal and pulling back the large, stone door, an elongated room spread

out before them. In the center of the room lay artifacts not from the time of Markidu's reign, save a scroll in situ. The scroll spoke that the artifacts were found in the lands to the North on a military conquest by an unnamed officer.

It was reported by one of the archaeologists, Arthur Johansen, that the artifacts were constructed out of a type of metal not known to the time and not known to current science. There were 40 polished rings—three 4 centimeters in diameter, fifteen 12 centimeters in diameter, and twenty-five between 14 and 16 centimeters in diameter, graduated in scale. Also, there were six metallic tubes and a strange metallic sphere that flaked large sections off if scraped with a tool. It was noted that the sphere absorbed light and glowed brilliantly when brought in from exposure to bright sunlight into the dark chambers. There were three bands across the surface of the sphere as if it were mounted in the set of the smaller rings. Johansen made a drawing of what the machine might have looked like if it were to be reassembled.

Shortly after discovering the artifacts, the British military was called to the site and the contents of the chamber were taken to University College London for study by government scientists. Johansen's report was classified and the artifacts disappeared from sight. It was rumored they were shipped clandestinely a few years later to the University of California for further study. At the time the laboratory was working on the research related to the first atomic bomb, and was reputed to have the most modern equipment to study the metallic properties of the artifacts. A leaked memo dated 25 March 1938 noted that the metallic objects were crystalline in structure and could not have been naturally occurring. It was concluded it must have been synthesized and recommended that a query into the work the Nazi scientists should be considered. That if they had constructed the artifacts they could build weapons of great power. Shortly after the memo, or so the story goes, the artifacts were shipped to an undisclosed location and quietly buried.

Dr. Uncler found Johansen's report while rooting through the archives of the British Museum. He also found the 1938 memo on a fragment of microfiche. In 1990, he published a paper *Means of Travel in the Ancient Stellar World* where he detailed the ancient machine and what its theoretical purpose might have been. There was no script reported on the artifacts but nevertheless argued that they comprised a machine that could create a pocket of independent, or in his words, null space-time where an individual or collection of individuals could use the pocket to move within

the entirety of time and space. He said that such a machine would allow the traveler to travel in time or in space independently, but not both. He exemplified that the machine could be directed to open a pocket where the distance say between here in Prague and Cydonia Mensae on Mars would be only a few meters instead of 75 million kilometers. Alternately, a pocket could be opened at a single point, say again in Prague, to a point in the past of hundreds to thousands to millions of years before. He did not detail if the future could be navigated in such a fashion and I would expect that such a feat is truly impossible since there is no real point for the machine to resonate with. Uncler noted that there is logic and a formed higher geometry to the space-time manifold which defines specific properties. It is the higher geometric system that allows a series of differentiated metrics whose complexity increases with time. He argued that a lower complexity metric of sufficient order can be specifically identified where the traveler could determine where or when he wanted to go. He called this process 'time dilation', in that time is not truly manipulated but dilated, opened up and made passive upon the manifold. In late 1992, Dr. Uncler constructed a prototype *Cipher* that was tested at a laboratory on the campus of the University of California. Although I suspected the work was classified and not be able to glean much information, I had the unique opportunity to conduct a phone interview with one of his associates and reputed Cipher project manager, Dr. Steven Sanderson. Dr. Sanderson, although vague in his answers to my questions, detailed that Uncler had conducted three unsuccessful tests and two successful tests with two unnamed colleagues. I asked him if he could provide any details about Uncler's Cipher but he passed over my request with 'Sorry, it's classified.' He directed me to Uncler's last publication regarding the machine; an article in the October 1993 issue of *Physics Today* from which the information for this article was obtained. There were few details about the machine itself, instead, the article framed Uncler's argument of a dynamic, controllable, space-time continuum. After this article, there is no further mention of Dr. Samuel Uncler except for critical reviews of said article where he is lambasted and ridiculed for his theories. Not even Carl Sagan would come to his rescue.

I searched the public records for Samuel Uncler to determine what may have happened to him. I performed this research on the new grid internet, a powerful version beyond the old internet of just a few years ago. I discovered he was born in Chicago in 1965, went to the University of Chicago where he got his undergraduate degree in Theoretical Physics in 1986. He then studied at University of California, where he received his doctorate in High-Energy Physics in 1991. He was last employed by the

University from 1990 to 1993. There is no mention if he was transferred or fired or if he resigned his commission at the government facility. I had filed a request under the Freedom of Information Act for employment and assignment records but so far there is no word. I then turned my attention to marriage and death certificates. Apparently, Dr. Uncler was married in 1987 to Jenine Goddard and had a daughter, Emilia in 1988. He was divorced in 1990 and there is no record of another marriage. Also, there is no record of death. Dr. Uncler held a passport that was not renewed after its expiration in 2002.

Between the past and the future lies what is undone. As with the tenet of physics, this is all there is regarding Dr. Samuel Uncler. If it begins with the Greeks and the Roman conception of time and space, it seems to end with Uncler in the only recorded time dilation experiment. Did he create a pocket whereby a person could travel to the far reaches of space and time? What has happened to him these past fifteen years? Was he reassigned to a classified project and his identity erased in a cloak-and-dagger Cold War style coup? Did he successfully travel to a far point in space where I am the twin in Einstein's paradox waiting until old age for his return? Or did he perish in one of his experiments and his death not recorded because of the nature of his demise? Many questions but few answers. It remains for time to uncover these mysteries...

That's about as far as I have gotten with the paper. I had originally conceived of this paper while dining at Tartino's on Fisherman's Wharf in San Francisco some ten years earlier but never pursued it. I thought I had forgotten the work until very recently. I was riding on the tram during what was supposed to be the summer. Instead of hot, sunny days, I was greeted with cold and rain. In my lingering depression and finding myself staring at the scenery passing by, the paper ebbed back into my thoughts and soon I found I was becoming obsessed with finishing it. I immediately went home and started writing in earnest; I should have been teaching a private lesson with a client named Daniela but I quickly canceled it. If I go on like this, I won't have any money at all. But right at this moment it doesn't matter. Besides, it seems my client is looking for more than just English lessons and being recently divorced, I wasn't looking for a new relationship in this foreign land. There were too many answers to questions in contrasting languages.

It is a Wednesday like any other here, the city calls to me. In the deafening roar of silence, the past and the present mingle like two lovers recently estranged. I have the urge to wander the streets, to walk upon the same

cobbles Goethe had and see myself as a twisted, post-modern Faust—sans tragedy. Today the sky is a deep grey, there is no distinction of clouds stretching to the horizon. Rain pummels the roofs of yawning buildings where the tourists take refuge and me, well, I stare blindly into the monochrome watercolor.